Western sanctions may not have caused Myanmar's economic and strategic push into the hands of the Chinese, as many foreign observers have argued. But Western policies certainly made it easier for China to implement its designs for Myanmar. This, in turn, caused the West to rethink its Myanmar policy. US strategic concerns were outlined as early as June 1997 in a *Los Angeles Times* article by Marvin Ott, an American security expert and former CIA analyst. 'Washington can and should remain outspokenly critical of abuses in Myanmar. But there are security and other national interests to be served … it is time to think seriously about alternatives,' Ott concluded.[45]

Geostrategic concerns, rather than issues such as human rights and democracy, caused a shift in Washington's Myanmar policy at the same time as many staunchly nationalistic Myanmar military officers were becoming increasingly dissatisfied with their country's heavy dependence on China. In order to understand Myanmar's policy shift, it is also instructive to look behind the façade of democracy that was introduced after the 2010 election. A classified military document written by Lieutenant Colonel Aung Kyaw Hla, who is identified as a researcher at Myanmar's prestigious Defence Services Academy, was completed and circulated internally as early as August 2004. Entitled 'A Study of Myanmar–US Relations', the main thesis of the 346-page dossier is that Myanmar's recent reliance on China as a diplomatic ally and economic patron had created a 'national emergency' that threatened the country's independence. According to the dossier, Myanmar would be able to normalize relations with the West only after implementing political reforms and electing a government instead of being ruled by a junta. In this way, the regime can deal with the outside world on more acceptable terms, Aung Kyaw Hla suggested.[46]

And it worked, although the turn took some doing. It was not until a general election had been held in Myanmar in November 2010 that relations with the United States improved. In early December 2011, US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton paid a high-profile visit to Myanmar, the first such trip by a top-ranking US official in more than 50 years. This was followed by a visit by President Barack Obama in November 2012, and, in May 2013, Thein Sein became the first Myanmar president to visit the United States since 1966.